



MARKETING LABS · CONTENT & COMMUNICATIONS

STEPPS Content Framework

Give people a good reason to pass your idea on.

Interactive STEPPS framework canvas for designing ethical, shareable marketing content.

Includes: framework reference · guidance by STEPPS element · printable worksheet

STEPPS Content Framework: reference

INTERACTIVE SHAREABILITY-PLANNING PROTOTYPE

STEPPS helps you design content, products and campaigns that people may find useful, meaningful, visible and worth talking about. Map each principle around a clear audience need, then test the result with real people rather than assuming attention equals value.

Sharing should be voluntary and informed. Do not use misinformation, manufactured outrage, hidden incentives, deceptive scarcity or personal-data exploitation to create reach. A strong campaign earns attention by being relevant, truthful, accessible and genuinely useful.

Your STEPPS canvas

Select an element to inspect its content choice, audience benefit, evidence and ethical constraint.

Elements mapped

Identity and status

Everyday recall

Meaningful feeling

Visible behaviour

Useful help

Memorable narrative

CAMPAIGN COVERAGE

All six elements are mapped. Prioritise clarity and usefulness over trying to force every mechanism into every content item.

AUDIENCE VALUE

Ask before publishing: does this help the intended audience understand, decide, connect or act in a way they would consider worthwhile?

TESTING DISCIPLINE

Every element has an evidence or ethics note. Test comprehension, trust, accessibility, relevance and practical use with representative audiences.

Shareability with integrity

- Is the core claim accurate, sourced where appropriate and clear about uncertainty, limitations and relevance?
- Would a reasonable audience member understand why they are seeing the content and whether it includes a commercial or sponsored message?
- Does the content give people a real choice to share, participate, subscribe or disengage without pressure or penalty?
- Are stories developed with consent, fair representation and context—particularly when they involve communities, vulnerable people or lived experience?
- Is the content accessible across language, reading level, captions, transcripts, colour contrast, image description and format choices where relevant?
- Will success be assessed through meaningful outcomes—such as comprehension, useful action, trust or community benefit—not only reach and engagement?

Guidance by STEPPS element

Social Currency

Triggers

Emotion

Public

Practical Value

Stories

STEPPS Content Framework: your canvas

Print this page or fill it in by hand. The interactive lab asks the same questions.

Campaign, content or idea

For example: Product launch, social campaign, video series or public-information resource

STEPPS element

☐ Social Currency ☐ Triggers ☐ Emotion ☐ Public ☐ Practical Value ☐ Stories

Creative or content choice

Describe the specific content, design or message choice.

Audience benefit

Why would the audience find this useful, meaningful or worth sharing?

Evidence, test or ethical boundary

How will you test the idea, and what guardrail prevents misleading or manipulative communication?

Planning aid, not advice. Test assumptions with evidence and consider privacy, accessibility, fairness and sustainability before acting.